

10 Businesses Under Rs. 50,000

Real ideas with real budgets you can start on weekends,
without quitting your job.

Before we start

This isn't "quit your job and chase your passion." It's ten specific, low-cost ideas you can start on the side, with a real budget attached to each. Check your employment contract for any moonlighting or conflict-of-interest clause before starting anything client-facing in the same industry as your employer.

1. How to pick one, in four questions

- **Time:** how many real hours a week can you commit, honestly — not aspirationally?
- **Skill fit:** does this use something you're already decent at, or does it need months of learning before it earns anything?
- **Upfront cost:** what's the true starting budget, including the boring stuff — packaging, a basic website, initial inventory?
- **Income timeline:** some ideas earn from week one (freelancing), others take months (a product-based business needing an audience first).

2. Ten ideas, with real budgets

1. Freelance writing or copywriting — Rs. 0–5,000

If you can write clearly, this earns from week one. Budget covers a portfolio website or profile on a freelance platform. Start by pitching 5 businesses in your existing network.

2. Social media management for local businesses — Rs. 5,000–15,000

Local shops, gyms, and clinics often have no consistent social presence. Budget covers a basic design tool subscription and a simple portfolio. Pitch 3 local businesses directly.

3. Reselling via Instagram/WhatsApp store — Rs. 10,000–30,000

Small-batch inventory (clothing, accessories, home goods) sold directly through social media, no warehouse needed. Start with a small first order to test demand before scaling.

4. Home baking or a tiffin service — Rs. 10,000–40,000

Budget covers ingredients, basic packaging, and FSSAI registration (required for food businesses above a small threshold). Start with a 5-person trial batch among neighbours.

5. Online tutoring — Rs. 0–5,000

Academic subjects or a skill you already have (a language, an instrument, spreadsheets). Budget covers a webcam or basic recording setup. Start with word-of-mouth in your building or old college network.

6. Weekend event photography — Rs. 0–50,000

Zero cost if you already own a decent camera; the full budget applies only if buying gear from scratch. Start by shooting free for 2–3 events to build a portfolio.

7. Print-on-demand merchandise — Rs. 5,000–15,000

Designs printed on t-shirts, mugs, or bags only when ordered — no inventory risk. Budget covers design software and initial marketing. Needs consistent design output to gain traction.

8. Local errand or concierge service — Rs. 5,000–20,000

Grocery runs, queue-standing, small deliveries for busy professionals in your area. Budget covers a basic phone plan and local flyers. Start hyper-local — one apartment complex first.

9. Excel/spreadsheet automation for small businesses — Rs. 0–5,000

If you're comfortable with formulas or basic scripting, small businesses will pay to automate manual spreadsheet work. Start by offering a free fix to one small business as a portfolio piece.

10. Reselling handmade or local crafts online — Rs. 15,000–50,000

Partner with local artisans and sell through an online marketplace or your own small store. Budget covers initial stock and basic packaging. Start with a small curated batch, not a wide catalogue.

3. The legal and tax basics

- **No registration needed to simply start** most of these as an individual — you can begin freelancing or small reselling without forming a company first.
- **GST registration** is generally required once turnover crosses a threshold (commonly cited as Rs. 20 lakh for services, Rs. 40 lakh for goods, lower for special category states) — confirm the current threshold before assuming you're exempt, as rules can change.
- **Presumptive taxation (Section 44AD/44ADA)** lets small businesses and professionals declare a flat percentage of turnover as income, without maintaining detailed books — worth checking if you qualify once income becomes meaningful.
- **Declare the income.** Side income still needs to be reported in your ITR under the appropriate head, even if it's modest — undeclared income is a bigger risk than the tax owed on it.
- **FSSAI registration** is mandatory for any food business, even small home-based ones, above a minimal turnover — check current requirements before selling food commercially.

4. Mistakes that stall a side business early

- **Spending the full budget before the first sale.** Start with the smallest viable version, and reinvest profits rather than upfront savings.
- **Not checking your employment contract.** Some employers restrict freelancing in overlapping industries — check before you build client relationships that could conflict.
- **Pricing too low to "just get started."** Underpricing trains your first customers to expect it permanently, and makes raising prices later harder.
- **Trying to do all ten at once.** Pick one, run it for 2–3 months, and only then decide whether to continue, pivot, or stop.

5. Quick answers to common questions

Do I need to tell my employer about a side business?

Check your employment contract for moonlighting or conflict-of-interest clauses. Even without a formal requirement, avoiding direct competition with your employer's business is the safer default.

How do I price my services if I have no experience?

Look at 3–5 comparable freelancers or businesses locally, price near the lower-middle of that range to start, and raise it once you have testimonials or repeat customers.

Should I register a company before starting?

Usually not necessary at the start. Most of these ideas can run as an individual (sole proprietor) with income simply declared in your personal ITR, until the business grows enough to justify formal registration.

6. Getting started checklist

- ✓ Pick one idea based on the four questions in Section 1 — don't pick based on hype alone.
- ✓ Check your employment contract for any restrictions.
- ✓ Set a small starting budget and stick to it for the first 2–3 months.
- ✓ Get your first 3 customers however possible — even at a discount, for testimonials.
- ✓ Track income from day one, even informally, so declaring it later is simple.
- ✓ Reassess after 90 days: continue, pivot, or stop — all three are valid outcomes.

This ebook is a planning aid, not legal or tax advice. Registration thresholds and requirements vary and change — confirm current rules with a chartered accountant or the relevant government portal before starting a commercial activity.